# TRUMP MANAGEMENT

## ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

You are asked to study the Deal and mentally devise a Plan to make the contract.

## TRUMP MANAGEMENT LESSON

When you play a suit contract the first, and usually most important, decision you need to make is whether to start by pulling trumps. Fortunately there is a rule for you to follow which is never wrong.

YOU SHOULD ALWAYS PULL TRUMPS IMMEDIATELY -
EXCEPT FOR THOSE TIMES WHEN YOU SHOULDN'T

This lesson and the Deals that go with it will show you those times.

**Always pull trumps immediately:**

The contract is 4♥ and West leads the ♠J.

♠ 7 3
♥ A J 9 4 2
♦ 9 6 4
♣ Q J 10




♠ A K Q
♥ K Q 10 5 3
♦ 8 7 3
♣ K 3

You have 3 losers in ♦s and 1 in ♣s.

You are ecstatic that West didn't lead a minor suit so you play your 3 high ♠s and discard a ♦ from dummy on the third one. Unfortunately East ruffs the ♠ and the defense takes their **2** ♦ tricks plus the ♣A.

This is a really basic example but I'll bet we have all seen it happen. Of course you should win the first trick, **THEN PULL TRUMPS**, then run the ♠s for the discard.

Too easy you say, and you are right. Probably everybody reading this would have pulled trumps.

Have you ever had someone, (your partner?), tell you that they couldn't pull trumps because the suit was too weak? Bad reasoning; with weak trumps and strong side suits you should lead trumps early and often.

The contract is 4♠ and West leads the ♣8.

♠ 7 4 3 2
♥ A K Q
♦ J 10 9
♣ K J 9




♠ 9 8 6 5
♥ J 10 9
♦ A K Q
♣ A Q 10

You have no losers in any suit except trumps.

And if the trumps split 3-2 you can HOPE to lose only 3 tricks there. So you should win the first trick and lead a trump - which you will lose. Win the next trick and play another trump - which you will lose. Win the next trick and lose one more trump if you like, it doesn't matter at this point.

But think what could happen if you didn't play on trumps at every opportunity. You could be leading high side suit cards and East ruffs a ♣ with the ♠10. Then West ruffs a ♥ with the ♠J. And East ruffs with the ♠Q, and West ruffs with the ♠K and somebody still has the ♠A. In other words the defenders had 5 high trumps and you let them make them all individually.

Point made.

**Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .**
**. . . you need to ruff tricks in dummy:**

The contract is 6♦ and West leads the ♦5.

♠ 8 5
♥ 9 6 5 2
♦ 7 4
♣ A K 7 4 2




♠ A K 4 3
♥ A K 3
♦ A K Q J 9
♣ 5

You have 2 losers in ♠s and 1 in ♥s.
You can pull trumps, then discard the ♥ loser on dummy's high ♣, but you will still be left with the 2 ♠s.

A better play is delay pulling trumps. Play the ♠ A K 4, ruffing the ♠4 with dummy's last trump. Then play a ♥ to your hand and now pull trumps.

You will still have 1 ♠ loser at the end but you will make the contract.

**Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .**
**. . . you need the trump suit for entries:**

The contract is 6♠ and West leads the ♣K.

♠ K Q 2
♥ 6 5 3
♦ 7 3 2
♣ 8 5 4 2




♠ A J 10 9 6 4
♥ A K
♦ A Q J
♣ A 7

With a sure ♣ loser you need to have the ♦ finesse.

Suppose trumps split 3-1 (probable) and you pull them ending in dummy. You can then take the ♦ finesse but even when it wins you are doomed because you cannot repeat it.

Instead win the first trick and play ♠A then small to dummy's ♠Q. Now finesse the ♦ successfully and return to the ♠K, pulling the last trump. Finesse the ♦ once more and claim.

**Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .**
**. . . you can't afford to lose the lead yet:**

Perhaps the reason you can't afford to lose the lead yet is that you need to discard a loser quickly. The contract is 5♣ and West leads the ♥Q.

♠ K Q 2
♥ 6 5 3
♦ A 8
♣ Q 6 5 4 3




♠ A 4
♥ A 7 2
♦ K 5 4
♣ K J 9 8 7

The ♥ lead has exposed your 2 ♥ losers early.

You can ruff the small ♦ in dummy, but you cannot avoid losing the Ace of trumps. If you lead a ♣ now the defenders will grab their ♣A and immediately cash their 2 ♥ tricks.

So before playing a trump you play 3 ♠s, discarding a ♥ on dummy's third ♠. Only then is it safe to start pulling trumps.

**Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .**
**. . . you plan to play a cross-ruff:**

The contract is 6♥ and West leads the ♦K.

♠ A
♥ Q J 9 7
♦ 9 8 7 5 3
♣ A 7 5




♠ 9 8 7 4 2
♥ A K 10 8
♦ A
♣ K 6 4

You can win your 4 side suit high cards, then alternate ruffing 4 ♠s in dummy and 4 ♦s in your hand.

One of the two keys to a cross-ruff is that you might not have enough winners if you play a round of trumps. In this deal, for example, you needed to make all 8 trumps individually; even one lead would have cost you two trumps for one winning trick.

The second key is that you must take any side-suit winners early. Here if you delay taking your ♣A and ♣K, one of the defenders might discard ♣s while you are playing the other suits and be able to ruff a ♣ winner late in the game.

**Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .**
**. . . you plan a dummy reversal:**

A mistake made frequently by beginners is taking an early ruff in the long-trump hand. When you ruff in the short-trump hand it does two good things - it gives you an immediate winner and it also gives you an extra winner. When you ruff in the long-trump hand it gives you an immediate winner but it seldom gives you an extra trick.

Look at these three hands:

You are playing a ♥ contract and West leads the ♣ A K.

♠ K J 7 2
♥ K Q J
♦ 6 5 4 3 2
♣ 2




♠ A Q 10 9 8
♥ A 10 9 8 7
♦ --
♣ 5 4 3

You can ruff 2 ♣s in dummy, the short-trump hand.

You will now make a total of 7 trump tricks, your 5 plus dummy's 2 ruffs.

Dummy's ruffs have actually gained you 2 tricks.

♠ K J 7
♥ K Q J
♦ 5 4 3 2
♣ 8 6 2




♠ A Q 10 9 8
♥ A 10 9 8 7
♦ A 6
♣ 3

You can ruff the second ♣ in your hand, the long-trump hand.

You could even ruff dummy's last ♣ if you wanted to, but it wouldn't help you.

Because ruffing in your hand hasn't gained you any tricks, you still only get 5 trump tricks.

♠ K J
♥ K Q J
♦ 5 4 3 2
♣ 8 6 4 2




♠ A Q 10 9 8
♥ A 10 9 8 7
♦ A 6
♣ 3

Ruff the second ♣ in your hand with the ♥A.
Play a ♥ to dummy's ♥J.
Ruff dummy's third ♣ in your hand.
Play a ♥ to dummy's ♥Q.
Ruff dummy's last ♣ with your last ♥.
Play a ♠ to dummy's ♠K.
Pull the opponents' last trump with dummy's ♥K, discarding your ♦ loser.
Overtake dummy's ♠J and your hand is good.
You actually made 6 trump tricks, 3 ruffs in your hand, and the 3 you pulled trumps with in dummy.

This is called a Dummy Reversal - because you used dummy's hand to pull trumps with, and took the ruffs in your own hand.

**Always pull trumps immediately: except when . . .**
**. . . the only trump left out is the master trump:**

The contract is 6♥ and West leads the ♠A.

♠ 7 2
♥ K 5 4
♦ A 3
♣ A K Q J 10 9




♠ --
♥ A Q 7 6 2
♦ K 9 8 4 2
♣ 4 3 2

You ruff the ♠A and start pulling trumps with the ♥K, then the ♥A. West follows with the ♥3, then discards a ♠ on the second ♥ play so you will lose a trick to East's ♥ J 10 9 8.

You continue with the ♥Q which leaves you with just the ♥7 remaining in your hand while East has the master ♥J. Should you play the final trump?

Heck no! If you did there would be no stopping the avalanche of ♠s they would play! Instead, just start running dummy's ♣s until East gets frustrated and ruffs with the ♥J. Of course that now leaves you with a trump to stop the ♠s.

Despite the above suggestion, there is a time when you do not want to leave the master trump left out - when dummy has a long suit to run but has no outside entries. Change the previous hand around.

The contract is 6♥ and West leads the ♠A.

♠ 7 3 2
♥ 5 4
♦ 4 3
♣ A K Q J 10 9




♠ --
♥ A K Q 7 6 2
♦ A 9 8 4 2
♣ 3 2

You ruff the ♠A and start pulling trumps with the ♥A, then the ♥K. West follows with the ♥3, then discards a ♠ on the second ♥, so you will lose a trump trick to East's ♥ J 10 9 8.

Suppose you pull just one more trump with the ♥Q, then switch to ♣s, leaving East with the master ♥J. No good. East will ruff the second or third ♣ and even though you will have trump control you won't have a way back to dummy's good ♣s.

Instead you go ahead and force Easts ♥J out with your ♥7, still leaving you with the ♥6. If East plays a ♠ you can ruff with the last trump and then run the ♣ suit uninterrupted.

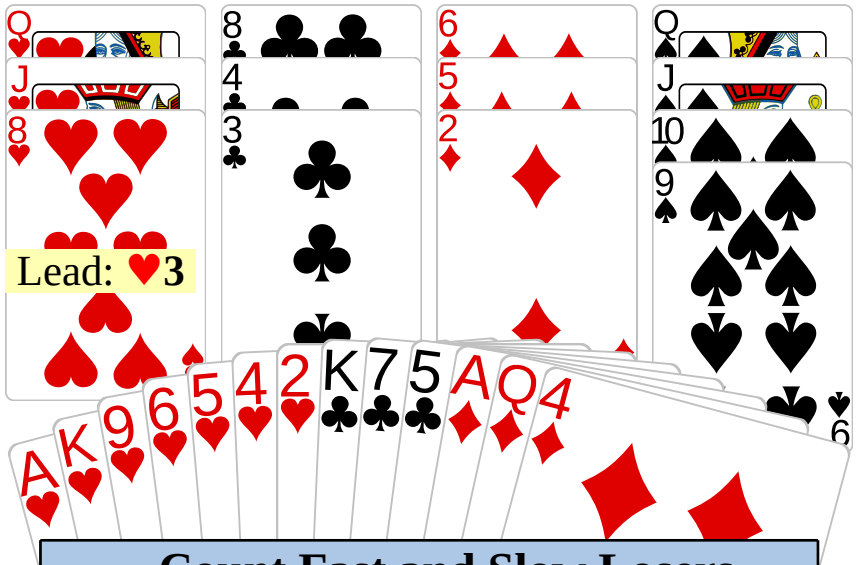
**The last word:**

This lesson and the practice Deals are mainly about the various times when you need to delay pulling trumps or perhaps not pull them at all. Don't let that give you the wrong idea though.

MOST OF THE TIME YOU SHOULD PULL TRUMPS IMMEDIATELY

. . . 20 examples should be worth more than another 2000 words.

**Deal 1** Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers




| Count Fast and Slow Losers | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ♠ | ♥ | ♦ | ♣ | Total |
| | | | | |
| **Decide How to Reduce Losers** | | | | |
| Ruffs | Finesse | Pitch | Length | |
| | | | | |

**Deal 2** Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



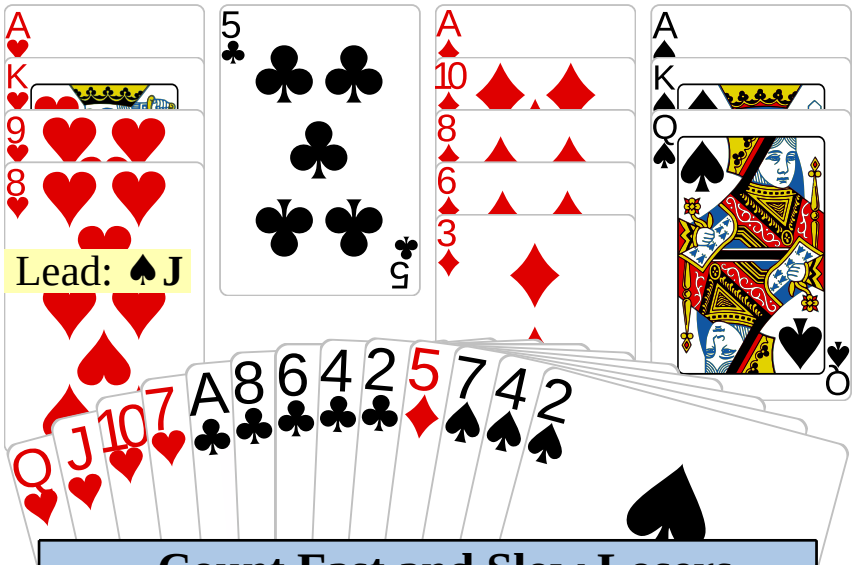

| Count Fast and Slow Losers | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ♠ | ♥ | ♦ | ♣ | Total |
| | | | | |
| **Decide How to Reduce Losers** | | | | |
| Ruffs | Finesse | Pitch | Length | |
| | | | | |

**Deal 3** Ctr: **6♥** Goal: at most ____ losers




| Count Fast and Slow Losers | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ♠ | ♥ | ♦ | ♣ | Total |
| | | | | |
| **Decide How to Reduce Losers** | | | | |
| Ruffs | Finesse | Pitch | Length | |
| | | | | |

**Deal 4** Ctr: **6♥** Goal: at most ____ losers




| Count Fast and Slow Losers | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ♠ | ♥ | ♦ | ♣ | Total |
| | | | | |
| **Decide How to Reduce Losers** | | | | |
| Ruffs | Finesse | Pitch | Length | |
| | | | | |

Board: 1
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥3

Board: 2
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: East
Lead: ♥K

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: South
Lead: ♠Q

Board: 4
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 6♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♠J

***Board 1***
West Deals
None Vul

♠ K 8 6 4 2
♥ —
♦ J 10 7 3
♣ Q J 10 2

♠ —
♥ A K 9 6 5 4 2
♦ A Q 4
♣ K 7 5




♠ A 7 5 3
♥ 10 7 3
♦ K 9 8
♣ A 9 6

♠ Q J 10 9
♥ Q J 8
♦ 6 5 2
♣ 8 4 3

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| Pass | 1♥ | Pass | 2♥ |
| Pass | 4♥ | | |
| All Pass | | | |

4♥ by North
Lead: ♥3

North is to play 4♥. East leads the ♥3.

West discards a ♠ and you play the ♥2.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=3 Total = 5

If West has the ♦K, one ♦ loser can be eliminated by a finesse. And, if West also has the ♣A one more loser can be eliminated by leading toward your ♣K. The chance of both cards being held by West isn't very good, only about 25%. But dummy has some nice ♠s. Can you use them?

West plays low.

Yes, you can establish 2 ♠ winners for discards, and most importantly, you can do it without letting West into the lead. This is important because if West gets in and plays a ♣ through your ♣ K 7 5 it might be a disaster.

So win the ♥J in dummy. Uh-Oh, West discards a ♠. Now play the ♠Q and when West plays low, discard a ♣. This is a loser on loser play and East takes the trick with the ♠A.

East now leads the ♥7. You cover with dummy's ♥8 knowing the finesse will win. Next you play dummy's ♠J, covered by West and ruffed by you (if West didn't cover you would throw another ♣ loser). Now enter dummy with the ♥Q, pulling East's last trump at the same time. Discard your 2 ♣s on the ♠ 10 9 and try the ♦ finesse for an overtrick.

This loser-on-loser play didn't have much to do with trump management.

Just the fact that you had to use the trump suit for entries to dummy, and therefore couldn't immediately pull trumps.

***Board 2***
North Deals
N-S Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ 10 5 2<br>♥ 10 9 3<br>♦ J 9 5 3<br>♣ K Q 8 | |
| ♠ K 6<br>♥ 8 5 4 2<br>♦ K 8 7 2<br>♣ 9 5 4 |  | ♠ A Q J 9 7 4<br>♥ A 6<br>♦ A Q<br>♣ 6 3 2 |
| | ♠ 8 3<br>♥ K Q J 7<br>♦ 10 6 4<br>♣ A J 10 7 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | Pass | 1♠ | Pass |
| 1NT | Pass | 4♠ | |
| All Pass | | | |

4♠ by East
Lead: ♥K

East is to play 4♠. South leads the ♥K, dummy plays the ♥2 and North the ♥3.

You win the ♥A and cash the ♠A.

South plays low.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=0 ♣=3 Total = 4

This is a very easy problem to be up here at number 18! Clearly you have to discard one of those 4 losers on the only card dummy has, the ♦K.

Just as clearly you have to be able to enter dummy after you unblock the ♦ A Q so you can't pull trumps immediately.

So here's the Plan. Win the ♥A. Pull one round of trumps with the ♠A. Play the ♦ A Q to get them out of the way. Enter dummy with the ♠K. Play the ♦K, discard a loser, and hope nobody ruffs.

Just remember to always pull trumps immediately . . .

. . . except when you have a good reason not to, like here.

***Board 3***
South Deals
None Vul

♠ Q J 10 7 3
♥ J 3
♦ 8 6 2
♣ J 9 5

♠ —
♥ 10 9 6
♦ K Q J 10 3
♣ A 8 7 4 2




♠ A 9 8
♥ Q 5 2
♦ 9 7 5 4
♣ Q 10 6

♠ K 6 5 4 2
♥ A K 8 7 4
♦ A
♣ K 3

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | | 1♠ |
| Pass | 2♦ | Pass | 3♥ |
| Pass | 4♥ | Pass | 4NT |
| Pass | 6♥ | | |
| All Pass | | | |

6♥ by South
Lead: ♠Q

North's 6♥ response to Blackwood showed one Ace and a ♠ void. South is to play 6♥. West leads the ♠Q.

East plays the ♠8 and you the ♠2.

Losers: ♠ = ?? ♥ = 1 ♦ = 0 ♣ = 0 Total = 1 ??

Of course you ruff the ♠ in dummy. West wouldn't underlead an Ace at a slam contract, and since you have a certain trump loser you cannot afford to lose a trick to East's ♠A.

Dummy has some great ♦s, but you can't expect to run them unless you have pulled all the trumps. But if you play ♥ A K 4 the defenders will take their trump trick and immediately set the contract with the ♠A. There **IS** a way around the problem.

East plays low.

West wins with the ♥J.

First off, you must get a 3-2 split in trumps because if they don't split 3-2 you will have two trump losers. So you assume that they are split just like you need them to be.

At trick two you duck a trump. That's right, you lose a trump trick early. Since you have to lose a trump sometime, you do it at a time when the defenders can't hurt you. So a defender wins the trump trick, but now a ♠ play won't hurt because dummy still has a trump to ruff with! In fact, whatever they play next you will win, pull the outstanding trumps, then run dummy's ♦ suit.

This is a very rare play, but a good one to remember.

When you have a trump loser but still need to pull their trumps, it may be better for you to lose an early trump trick rather than a later one.

***Board 4***
East Deals
Both Vul

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| | ♠ J 10 9 8 3<br>♥ 6<br>♦ K J 9 7 4<br>♣ J 10 | |
| ♠ 7 4 2<br>♥ Q J 10 7<br>♦ 5<br>♣ A 8 6 4 2 | N<br>W E<br>S | ♠ A K Q<br>♥ A K 9 8<br>♦ A 10 8 6 3<br>♣ 5 |
| | ♠ 6 5<br>♥ 5 4 3 2<br>♦ Q 2<br>♣ K Q 9 7 3 | |

| *West* | *North* | *East* | *South* |
|---|---|---|---|
| | | 1♦ | Pass |
| 1♥ | Pass | 4NT[1] | Pass |
| 5♦[2] | Pass | 6♥ | |
| All Pass | | | |

1. Blackwood
2. 1 ace

6♥ by West
Lead: ♠J

Agreed that the bidding wasn't much. The final contract is still a good one. West is to play 6♥. North leads the ♠J.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=0 ♦=0 ♣=4 Total = 4

There really aren't 4 ♣ losers since they can be ruffed in dummy. In fact you should see that this is an ideal cross-ruff hand, ruffing ♣s in dummy and ♦s in your hand. Since neither hand can be over-ruffed you expect to make all 8 trumps.

Remember, when playing a cross ruff, you need to take any side suit winners first, otherwise a defender may be able to discard that suit while you are ruffing. So you win the ♠A, then take the ♠K, then . . . what?

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=0 ♦=0 ♣=4 Total = 4

There really aren't 4 ♣ losers since they can be ruffed in dummy. In fact you should see that this is an ideal cross-ruff hand, ruffing ♣s in dummy and ♦s in your hand. Since neither hand can be over-ruffed you expect to make all 8 trumps.

Remember, when playing a cross ruff, you need to take any side suit winners first, otherwise a defender may be able to discard that suit while you are ruffing. So you win the ♠A, then take the ♠K, then . . . what?

Well, if you win the ♠Q, then the two Minor suit Aces, you'd be set up to cross-ruff the hand out for all 13 tricks. But here's what might happen if you try.

South might ruff the ♠Q. OK, no disaster yet. But he might then play a trump. Your slam is now kaput. You can no longer make 8 trump tricks and will end up down 1.

The answer is to not be greedy for that overtrick. With North's opening ♠ lead there is an indication of possible length there. So, realizing that South could be short in the suit, take just the 2 ♠ tricks that you need for the slam, then play your Minor Aces and start the cross-ruff.

When playing a cross-ruff you must take all the side-suit winners you need early so they won't get ruffed later.

Don't jeopardize your contract trying to take too many.